

SKOAR!

E3 2011: Games of the Show

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E3 2011 was filled with great games, but which ones stood out among the crowd as the best? Which games had people really talking? Some of them were expected but a few took us a bit by surprise.

The first game that stood out to me is XCOM (Xbox 360, PS3, PC) from 2K Games. It may not be the game everyone else is talking about but when it releases March 6, 2012 it is almost certainly going to be a huge hit. Developed by 2K's Marin studio it is a re-imagining of the classic XCOM universe, this time with first-person shooter gameplay and role playing elements. You take the role of William Carter, an FBI operative, as he tries to investigate and uncover the mystery of an unknown alien threat. As a throwback to the original tactical strategy games, the story will not play out in a linear or straight-forward manner. You have a base of operation to work from and the freedom to choose which missions to take and in which order. Additionally, you have access to several other field operatives from which to build your team, all of which can earn upgrades and be customized by the player. In each mission you take two of them with you and it is in your benefit to build a balanced team. During the mission you can enter tactical mode to issue commands to your teammates. Another aspect of the gameplay that makes it unique is the ability to capture alien technology. You are investigating the aliens, after all, not just combating them. Often

when an enemy is defeated they will leave bits of their advanced technology behind. One such example was shown during the E3 demo, as an advanced gun turret was left behind. The player then has the option to either bring it back to base (which results in weapon upgrades being discovered) or redeploying it as a weapon in the current mission. The latter option results in devastating damage and immediate results while the former provides a long lasting benefit. If you redeploy it you cannot bring it back with you for research which means the game can be played in multiple ways depending on what each player prefers.

Perhaps more than for its gameplay XCOM stands out for its style and art direction, much like the original Bioshock did when it released. Set in the United States in 1962, the game takes place between the carefree 1950s and the upcoming social tensions of the 1960s. The entire game is designed to look like an old detective film. The setting isn't cleaned up and politically correct for modern audiences. Characters have bravado and arrogance, and it is a time when people still smoked in their offices and sipped whiskey during the afternoon. It's rough, gritty, and different from most games currently available. Combined with the storyline centered on an unknown (and secret to the general public) alien threat, the best way to

describe it is X-Files meets Mad Men.

Coming as much less of a surprise, The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim (360, PS3, PC) was one of the most impressive games on display and for those lucky enough to see it, one of the most talked about. With executive producer Todd Howard at the controls, it was obvious from the opening of the demo that this game would be infinitely grander than Oblivion ever was. It is clear that Bethesda took to heart everything gamers complained about. Character models are easily recognized as being hugely improved with much better facial details. For those who like to play in third-person mode, the main character's animation has been re-worked and he now feels attached to the surface rather than appearing to float across it. They have removed stats like athletics and acrobatics so that you can no longer practice jumping so much that you can jump over a mountain. Even the basic details like the menu system have been redesigned for convenience. The new menu system is quick, unobtrusive, and contains full 3D animated renderings of every item in the game.

The demo opens in the mountains, covered in snow, overlooking a small village. That snow wasn't placed there by an artist. Instead the entire weather system is dynamic and snow builds in high elevations during storms and will dissipate with time. As we wander in to the town we are told that each job can be performed by the player, and the local economy can be impacted by things you do. If you destroy

